

CONFABULATION Rahul Gandhi with Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge in Delhi, Nov. 26

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While welfare schemes helped NDA neutralise INDIA's call for redistributive justice, they also reflect how large sections of people still depend on doles

that needs to be treasured, not trashed."

The jury is still out though on the communally polarising campaigns in this round of elections. It remained a potent weapon in the BJP's arsenal, with Uttar Pradesh chief minister Yogi Adityanath raising the openly divisive slogan—*'Batenge to katenge'*—while campaigning in the state. After protest by NDA partners such as the NCP, Modi tamed that rhetoric with his own clarion call of *'Ek hai to safe hai'*, which the BJP says was responsible for galvanising its core supporters in Maharashtra. The BJP's divisive campaign did not work in Jharkhand though, where Assam chief minister Himanta Biswa Sarma imported the Bangladeshi immigrant bogey of his own state. The Election Commission, too, put a stop to the offensive video on Muslims. Meanwhile, rather than fall into the BJP trap, Hemant Soren turned the tables on the saffron camp by saying that checking infiltration was the Union home ministry's responsibility and asking why it had failed to arrest any of these illegal immigrants so far.

The Agenda Ahead

Overall, the larger message from this round of elections seems to be that people vote for welfare, development and jobs, and the yield from stoking communal tensions is modest at best. Modi 3.0 should now focus both on enhancing ease of living for people and ensuring economic growth and jobs, experts advise. The freebie culture, they say, reflects how large sections of the poor still depend on government doles despite the impressive GDP growth levels the country has seen post Covid. Healthcare at the primary level and education to upgrade skills are areas that continue to lag. While PM Modi has announced several landmark initiatives in his past two terms, they need a radical revamp, say experts, including timebound and targeted implementation, as was done in the case of Swachh Bharat. Telemedicine, for instance, could be one way to address the shortage of trained medical personnel at primary healthcare centres. Other experts want the prime minister to launch a campaign to eliminate corruption at the taluk and district levels to ensure efficient and hassle-free delivery of welfare entitlements or services.

Alongside, Modi 3.0 needs to revisit the unfulfilled agenda of boosting farm incomes and productivity. Infrastructure spend on agriculture, says former Union agriculture secretary Dr Siraj Hussain, has dipped considerably, including for storage of produce. Nor have farmers been given adequate incentives to diversify to the more lucrative horticultural crops, with poll sops still focusing on increasing minimum support prices for paddy and wheat. Manufacturing needs attention too; Kant wants the central government to act as a facilitator for the private sector to create jobs. The scheme for boosting government funding for R&D has yet to take off, he adds. Exports could emerge as another area of opportunity as Donald Trump's disruptive protectionist policies, including raising tariffs against China, could create space for India to emerge as an alternative in the global supply chain. The government should also press the pedal on its privatisation drive and derive more funds for its development projects.

Modi 3.0 now has the mandate. Fortified by the comfort of big wins in states after the setback in the general election, the prime minister can now move ahead rapidly on his agenda for Viksit Bharat. The nation waits with anticipation. ■